“What Do We Have to Do After Medicaid Approves a Parent?” and Other Questions Families Ask When Planning Ahead

Eight plain answers in general terms, and who to ask for the rest.

Someone in the family says that once a person is approved for Medicaid, that's that. Someone else has heard there are renewals. Nobody is quite sure. These are the questions that come up, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Dad in particular, and none is about a particular state. Where the honest answer is “it depends on the state and the situation,” it says so, and says who to ask.

1 What do we have to do after Medicaid approves a parent?

In general, read the mail and answer what it asks. The federal renewal flyer says a state mails a letter about a person's coverage, and that the letter says whether a renewal form or other information is needed. Beyond that it depends on the state and the situation, because each state decides how to run its own program. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what this would look like where Dad lives. Your Medicaid planner can explain it in general terms; if Dad ever had Medicaid, the agency's own letters would be the authority on what it asks of him.

2 So an approval isn't permanent?

Not necessarily. A renewal is the state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify, and states are required to do this through periodic renewals. KFF explains that when a coverage period is ending the state sends a notice: if coverage was renewed automatically it gives the new coverage period, and if not it includes instructions. [1] [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like to know how often a review would happen for someone in Dad's situation. That depends on the state and the kind of coverage.

3 What changes do we need to report?

It depends on the state and the situation, and a general guide can't list them for Dad. What the sources support is this: changes in a person's life, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income, can change their Medicaid eligibility, and states have procedures for people to report changes that may affect it. If Dad ever had Medicaid, his agency's own notices would say what to report and how. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a change is on the way, such as a move, a sale or a marriage, and you want to know whether it would matter. Bring it to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney before anyone acts.

4 Could a parent lose Medicaid after being approved?

Eligibility is looked at again, so a state's answer can change. If a state decides a person no longer qualifies, it says so in a letter, and the letter explains how to appeal. A person who disagrees with certain decisions has the right to ask for a fair hearing, and the flyer adds that a person can reapply at any time to find out whether they qualify. [1] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to understand what could change the answer for someone in Dad's situation. That takes someone who knows his state, such as your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

5 What if money arrives that nobody expected, like an inheritance?

How unexpected money is treated depends on the state and the situation, and this guide gives no rule for it. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money calls Medicaid complicated and says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility. The family's part is to write down what it is, who it came from and the date. [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** an inheritance, an insurance payment or the proceeds of a sale is expected or has arrived. Ask an elder law attorney or your Medicaid planner before anyone decides what to do with it.

6 Dad isn't on Medicaid. Is there anything to do now?

There is nothing to file or answer: Dad has no case, and no letter has come. What a family can do while things are calm is small: know where Dad's records are, ask him who he'd want handling the mail and the paperwork if he ever wanted a hand, write down the changes that may be coming, and pick a date to look at it all again.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something significant changes in Dad's health, his finances or his care. In the roadmap, that is when the plan is reviewed with your Medicaid planner.

7 What records should we be keeping, and where?

The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau recommends organizing important financial documents in a safe, easily accessible location, and giving copies to trusted loved ones or letting them know where to find them. Its list includes bank and brokerage statements, a list of accounts, a list of debts and regular payments, and contact details for doctors, lawyers and accountants. That advice isn't about Medicaid. It's about a second person being able to find things. [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know which records a Medicaid agency in Dad's state would ask for, or how long to keep them. That depends on the state, and it's a question for your Medicaid planner.

8 Who answers the questions this guide can't?

A state's Medicaid agency is where a person applies and finds out whether they are eligible, and Medicaid.gov keeps a directory of every state's agency. In the roadmap, your Medicaid planner explains in general terms what ongoing eligibility involves and reviews the plan with the family after significant changes. Legal questions and legal documents belong to an elder law attorney; the Family Caregiver Alliance lists a local Area Agency on Aging, a state senior legal hotline, or an attorney who specializes in elder law as ways to find legal help. [8] [9]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell which kind of professional a question belongs to. Write it under “not sure” and bring it to your Medicaid planner.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Dad himself or about his state. It doesn't say what would have to be reported, how any change would be treated, or whether he will ever need Medicaid. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions, and you know which ones belong to a professional. The planning interview is where the questions become about your own family: it asks about your situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started
3. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
4. KFF, Do I have to renew Medicaid coverage every year?
5. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Understanding Medicaid Fair Hearings
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
7. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
8. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?
9. Family Caregiver Alliance, What should I do to help get my family member's legal and financial affairs in order?